

Toi Māori

Executive Summary

Toi Māori is the creative expression of knowledge systems, governance, communication, spirituality, and survival.

Poverty is the result of deliberate policy choices.

In Te Ao Māori, art is both a tool and source of authority and holistic wellbeing.

Te Pāti Māori will restore Māori authority over Toi Māori as a total wellbeing strategy, protecting our indigenous voice and ensuring our people determine how it is carried into the future.

Context

Māori creativity has always been inseparable from oranga Māori. Our carving, weaving, performance, language, design, and storytelling are not optional cultural expressions but systems of survival.

The Crown has relegated Toi Māori to the margins, treating it as an “arts sector” under ministries that fragment its value and underfund its impact. This has constrained Māori ability to design, protect, and project our own cultural intellectual property.

Funding inequities remain stark. Te Matatini reaches tens of thousands in person and millions through broadcast, yet receives a fraction of the funding allocated to Western institutions with smaller audiences.

This imbalance reflects a failure to recognise that Toi Māori as central to Māori wellbeing.

Our Position

Toi Māori is a total wellbeing strategy for Māori.

It sustains identity, strengthens language, restores connection to whenua, supports physical and mental health, creates economic opportunity, and carries mātauranga across generations.

Māori must be the sole determinants of how our cultural intellectual property is protected and projected, at home and internationally.

Te Pāti Māori will...

1. Establish Māori Control of Toi Māori

Establish an independent Toi Māori authority, Māori-led and Māori-controlled.

- Operate the authority on a commissioning model dedicated to all forms of Toi Māori.
- Ensure decision-making power sits with Māori.

2. Secure Statutory Status and Funding Parity

- Make the Toi Māori authority a Statutory Body.
- Place it on the Lottery Grants Board.
- Fund it at parity with Creative NZ.

3. Invest in Evidence for Oranga Māori

- Establish a $10m Toi Māori research fund.
- Build a robust evidence base demonstrating Toi Māori's contribution to:
    - Oranga Māori
    - Education
    - Health
    - Social cohesion
    - Economic outcomes.
- Use this evidence to secure equitable funding across all sectors.

4. Strengthen Kapa Haka and Community Toi

- Ensure $19m baseline funding to Te Matatini.
- Allocate $10m to community, hapū, and iwi kapa haka and associated art forms.
- Recognise kapa haka as a central transmission pathway for language, identity, and wellbeing.

5. Protect and Project Indigenous Voice

- Ensure Māori control how Toi Māori is presented locally and internationally.
- Protect Māori cultural intellectual property from exploitation.
- Reject Crown ownership or mediation of Māori creativity.

6. Protect our Ringa Toi

- Guaranteed income scheme for artists.
- Ensure the state pays a living wage to employed and contracted artists, and encourages organisations employing artists to develop policies to pay them a living wage.
- Protect the integrity of Māori Art through WAI262.

Our Commitment

When Māori control our creativity, we control our narrative.

When we control our narrative, we protect our future.

When Toi Māori is upheld, oranga Māori is strengthened for generations to come.